

❖ STUDY BEES ❖

POEM – THE SOLITARY REAPER

by
William Wordsworth

- About the Poem
- Paraphrasing
- Rhyming Scheme
- Figures of Speech
- Theme
- Questions & Answers

About the Poem

"The Solitary Reaper" is a well-known lyric poem by William Wordsworth, published in 1807 and inspired by his and his sister Dorothy's travels through the Scottish Highlands. Written in four eight-line stanzas, the poem describes a lone young woman singing a melancholy, unintelligible song as she harvests grain in a field, and reflects on the deep, lasting effect her song has on the poet, even though he cannot understand its words.

Paraphrasing

Stanza 1:

*Behold her, single in the field,
Yon solitary Highland Lass!
Reaping and singing by herself;
Stop here, or gently pass!
Alone she cuts and binds the grain,
And sings a melancholy strain;
O listen! for the Vale profound
Is overflowing with the sound.*

Paraphrasing:

The poet asks the reader to look at a young Highland woman working alone in a field, cutting and gathering grain while singing to herself in a sad tune. He urges us to either stop and listen or pass by very quietly, so as not to disturb her, noting that the whole deep valley seems filled to overflowing with the sound of her song.

Stanza 2:

*No Nightingale did ever chaunt
More welcome notes to weary bands
Of travellers in some shady haunt,
Among Arabian sands:
A voice so thrilling ne'er was heard
In spring-time from the Cuckoo-bird,
Breaking the silence of the seas
Among the farthest Hebrides.*

Paraphrasing:

The poet declares that not even a nightingale singing to exhausted travellers resting in a shady spot among the Arabian desert sands could produce a more welcome song. Nor has any cuckoo-bird's springtime call, breaking the silence around the remote Hebridean islands, ever sounded as thrilling as the reaper's voice.

Stanza 3:

*Will no one tell me what she sings?—
Perhaps the plaintive numbers flow
For old, unhappy, far-off things,
And battles long ago:
Or is it some more humble lay,
Familiar matter of to-day?
Some natural sorrow, loss, or pain,
That has been, and may be again?*

Paraphrasing:

The poet wonders aloud what the song is actually about, since he cannot understand her Gaelic words. He speculates that it might be a sorrowful ballad about old tragedies and long-ago battles, or perhaps something much more ordinary and present-day – some everyday sorrow, loss, or pain that has happened before and could happen again.

Stanza 4:

*Whate'er the theme, the Maiden sang
As if her song could have no ending;
I saw her singing at her work,
And o'er the sickle bending;—
I listened, motionless and still;
And, as I mounted up the hill,
The music in my heart I bore,
Long after it was heard no more.*

Paraphrasing:

Whatever its true subject, the young woman sang as though her song might never end, continuing steadily as she bent over her sickle at work. The poet stood completely still, listening intently; and even after he had climbed the hill and could no longer hear her, he carried the memory of her music within his heart long afterward.

Rhyming Scheme

Each eight-line stanza generally follows an ABABCCDD rhyme pattern (with some variation, since the first and third lines are sometimes left unrhymed), written mainly in iambic tetrameter. This flowing, song-like structure – itself almost musical – mirrors the very song the poem describes, reinforcing the poem's meditation on music, memory, and solitary beauty.

Theme

"The Solitary Reaper" explores the power of music and beauty to move us deeply even when we cannot fully understand their meaning. Wordsworth, a central figure of English Romanticism, celebrates the ordinary, rural figure of a working woman as a source of profound emotional and artistic experience, and

reflects on how such a fleeting moment of beauty can leave a lasting impression on memory and feeling, carried “long after it was heard no more.”

Figures of Speech

• Imagery

Vivid visual imagery (“single in the field,” “o’er the sickle bending”) and auditory imagery (the valley “overflowing with the sound”) bring the scene and song vividly to life.

• Simile / Comparison

The reaper’s voice is compared favourably to the songs of the nightingale and the cuckoo-bird, emphasising its extraordinary beauty.

• Apostrophe

The poet directly addresses the reader (“Behold her...”, “O listen!”), inviting them into the scene as fellow observers.

• Rhetorical Question

“Will no one tell me what she sings?” expresses the poet’s genuine, unresolved curiosity about the song’s meaning.

• Symbolism

The solitary reaper and her song symbolise the timeless, universal power of music and human experience, transcending language and understanding.

• Hyperbole

Claiming that no nightingale or cuckoo ever sang “more welcome notes” exaggerates the beauty of her voice for poetic effect.

• Enjambment

Several lines flow into the next without a pause, echoing the continuous, unbroken quality of the reaper’s song.

Questions & Answers

Q1. What is the Highland lass doing in the poem?

She is reaping and binding grain alone in a field while singing a melancholy, unintelligible song to herself.

Q2. What does the poet ask the reader to do upon seeing her?

He asks the reader to either stop and listen to her song or pass by gently, so as not to disturb her.

Q3. To which two birds does the poet compare the reaper’s singing, and why?

He compares it to the nightingale, which sings to weary desert travellers, and the cuckoo-bird’s spring song in the remote Hebrides, claiming her voice surpasses both in beauty.

Q4. Why can the poet not understand what the reaper is singing about?

She is likely singing in Scottish Gaelic, a language the English poet does not understand, so he can only guess at her song’s meaning.

Q5. What two possible subjects does the poet imagine for her song?

He imagines it could be about old, sorrowful historical events and battles long ago, or about some ordinary, present-day sorrow, loss, or pain.

Q6. What effect does the reaper's song have on the poet by the end of the poem?

Even after he has climbed the hill and can no longer hear her, the music stays with him, carried “in his heart” long after the actual sound has faded.

Q7. What is the central theme of the poem?

The poem explores how music and beauty – even when their exact meaning is unknown – can move us deeply and leave a lasting emotional impression.

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